Apple Mail images not loading: diagnosis plan + Klaviyo sample

Emmanuel Marquez · HTML Email Developer

What usually stops images loading in Apple Mail (when only some fail after compressing)

If most images load and three don't, the problem is almost always **those files or their URLs**, not file size. Compression shrinks KB but leaves the pixels and encoding as they were. In order of how often I see it:

1. **Pixel dimensions too large.** iOS Mail can fail to decode very wide or very tall images, such as a 3000px+ export or a long single-image "poster" email. *Fix:* export at 2× display size (1200px wide for a 600px email) and slice very tall graphics into stacked images.
2. **Color mode / encoding.** CMYK JPEGs (common when exported for print), 16-bit or interlaced PNGs, AVIF/HEIC, or unusual progressive encodes. *Fix:* re-export as sRGB baseline JPEG or 8/24-bit PNG.
3. **Where the image is hosted.** With Mail Privacy Protection, Apple fetches images through its own proxy servers. Images hosted outside Klaviyo (Google Drive, Dropbox, a site or CDN with hotlink or bot protection) can be blocked or redirected for those requests. So can `http://` links, file names with spaces or special characters, and expiring signed URLs. *Fix:* upload to Klaviyo's image library and re-link.
4. **Heavy animated GIFs.** Large dimensions × many frames can show blank or only the first frame on iPhone. *Fix:* fewer frames, smaller canvas, 1–2 MB max.
5. **Markup.** The image is a CSS `background-image` with no fallback, uses `srcset` or `loading="lazy"`, or has no `width` attribute inside a Klaviyo text block. *Fix:* plain `<img>` with absolute https src, width/height attributes and `display:block`.

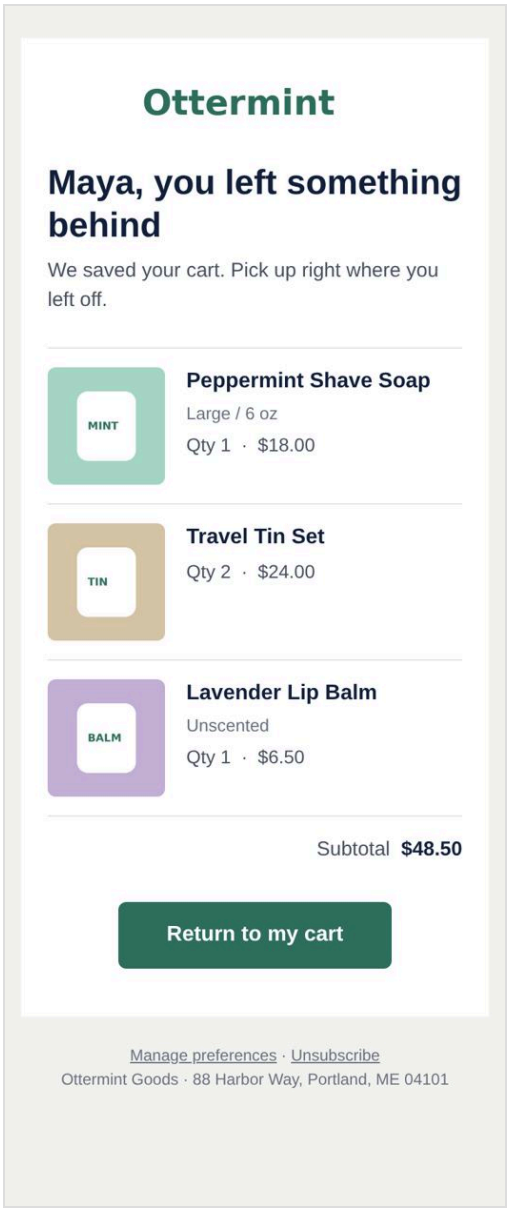
How I'd fix your client's newsletter (first hour)

1. Pull the three failing image URLs from the sent HTML. Check pixel size, color profile and format (`identify -verbose` / exiftool) against the images that do load.
2. Check each URL's response (`curl -sI`): status, redirects, content-type, and anything that blocks non-browser requests.
3. Re-export or re-host the culprits, then send Klaviyo previews to an iPhone (Mail Privacy Protection on and off) and run Litmus / Email on Acid across Apple Mail, Gmail and Outlook before the next send.
4. Write the cause into a one-line pre-send checklist so it doesn't come back.

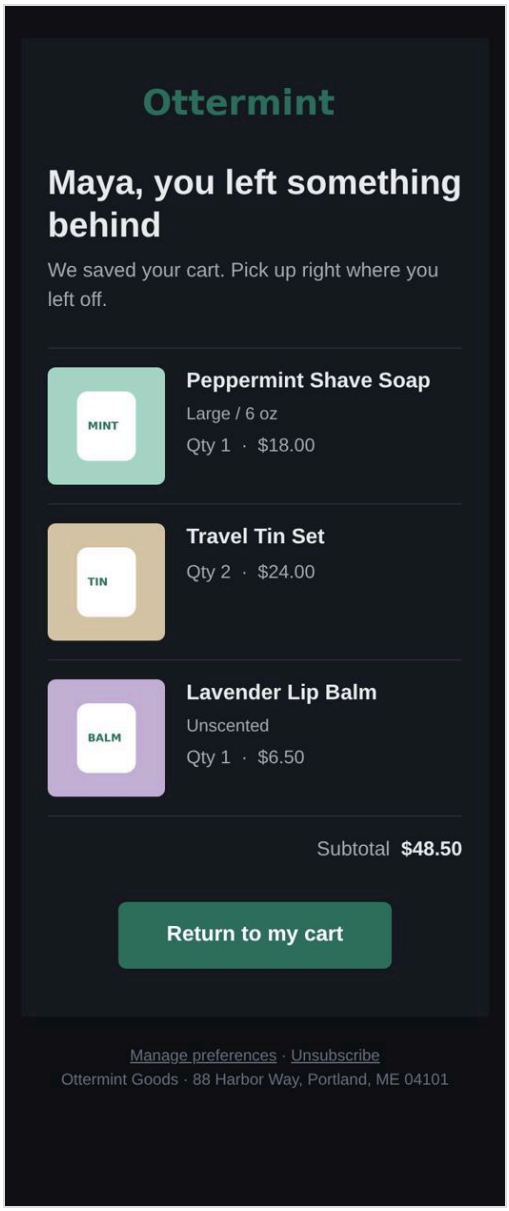
Klaviyo example: dynamic abandoned-cart template

Concept build for a fictional brand (Ottermint), made for this proposal. Hand-coded HTML for a Klaviyo "Started Checkout" flow, shown with sample data.

Light (iPhone width)



Dark (Apple Mail prefers-color-scheme)



Dynamic product loop (Klaviyo / Shopify Started Checkout)

```
{% for item in event.extra.line_items %}
  <img src="{{ item.product.images.0.src|default:'https://.../placeholder.png' }}" width="110" height="110"
       alt="{{ item.product.title }}" style="display:block;width:110px;height:auto;">
  {{ item.product.title }}
  {% if item.variant_title and item.variant_title != 'Default Title' %}{{ item.variant_title }}{% endif %}
  Qty {{ item.quantity }} · ${{ item.line_price|floatformat:2 }}
{% endfor %}
Subtotal ${{ event|lookup:'$value'|floatformat:2 }}
<a href="{{ event.extra.responsive_checkout_url }}">Return to my cart</a>   (VML button for Outlook)
```

Apple Mail-safe image rules are built in: absolute https sources, explicit width/height, `display:block`, no srcset or lazy-loading, and a placeholder fallback when a product has no image. Full source attached (abandoned_cart.klaviyo.html), with a dark-mode palette, mobile stacking and Klaviyo compliance tags.